



PHOTOGRAPHS BY ADRIANA LOUREIRO FERNANDEZ FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES
An informal mining operation in El Callao, Venezuela, where a state-owned company produces gold shipped to the United States.

On Your Dime, Trump Reuses Campaign Ad

By BAYLISS WAGNER

As President Trump ran to return to the White House in 2024, his campaign released a somber, black-and-white ad in which he railed against the “deep state” and vowed to expel “warmongers” from government.

“This is the final battle,” Mr. Trump is heard saying in the on-line ad, which shows him walking silently down a hallway.

That ad returned over the weekend, airing on television stations across the country, with one notable difference: As it ended, the words “Paid for by the U.S. Government” appeared on the screen.

The spot is the latest in a series of pro-Trump ads funded by public money. Some ethics experts have argued that the Trump administration is violating federal laws banning the use of taxpayer dollars for propaganda, and the ads have drawn criticism from both parties. The most recent ad, one expert argued, is a more flagrant violation given its prior use in the political arena.

“The president and his administration have gone from breaking the law to trampling it,” said Norm Eisen, a former White House special counsel for ethics and government reform under President Barack Obama, who has sued the Trump administration several times. “The prior ad was bad enough, but this one openly repurposes prior political conduct.”

The ad aired during “Fox News Sunday,” “Saturday Night Live”

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Shaped by Alaska, Peltola Rose Despite Bumps

By MICHAEL KRUSE

KWETHLUK, Alaska — Hard by the murky brown water of the Kuskokwim River, in a region reachable only by plane or boat, past weather-stunted willows and crude seasonal fish camps, dogs roamed muddy, rutted roads under low, dreary skies.

Here in the small village of Kwethluk in the vast tundra of southwestern Alaska, in the window of a house with unpainted sides and rotting wood steps, was

Run for Senate Reflects Her Complex Politics and Origin Story

“Mary’s great-grandma and my grandpa were half sister, half brother,” Mr. Nicori said. Her mother was a girl here, Mr. Nicori said. She was a girl here.

“She understands how we struggle,” he said. “She is one of us.”

Ms. Peltola, a former congresswoman, is an uncommonly capable candidate. In Alaska, where Republicans far outnumber Democrats and independents far outnumber both, she is the rare member of her party who has proved

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ALINA SMUTKO/REUTERS
Fear in the Heart of Kyiv
A Russian jet-powered drone struck Ukraine’s historic National Academy of Sciences. Page A8.

Mamdani Casts Shadow on Hochul’s Re-election

By BENJAMIN ORESKES

On a recent Sunday, Gov. Kathy Hochul wandered down Roosevelt Avenue in Woodside, Queens, a stronghold of New York City’s democratic socialist movement.

She embraced curious passersby and business owners, gamely posing for selfies as she hoped to capture the kind of voter excitement that Zohran Mamdani generated in his run for mayor.

But as she strode past Filipino street vendors grilling chicken intestines, it was fairly apparent that Ms. Hochul, who is running for re-election in November, was missing something: the presence of Mr. Mamdani.

Since taking office, Mr. Mamdani has shown how his star power can excite Democratic voters and decisively influence elections across New York City. His support could be crucial for Ms. Hochul, given that the young progressive masses that powered his victory last year continue to view the governor, a moderate Democrat from Buffalo, with a mix of skepticism and derision.

Yet so far, Mr. Mamdani has done little to outwardly help Ms. Hochul’s re-election bid against

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A Phone-Free Show? You’ll Live, in Every Sense.

Outside the Barclays Center in Brooklyn on Thursday evening, just before the first of Phoebe Bridgers’s three sold-out shows, people were using their phones with a frenzied urgency. Some chatted with loved ones in that hurried, “if I make it to the other side” tone normally reserved for the moments right before a plane is about to take off. Others frantically snapped selfies and photos of their friends’ outfits, many of which nodded toward Bridgers’s macabre aesthetic and penchant for wearing skeleton suits.

Though it was well outside of business hours, I quickly thumbed out a work email that probably could have waited until morning. I then joined the long, crawling line to surrender my electronic devices into a securely locked Yondr pouch and, for the next three hours or so, mandatorily live in the moment.

Bridgers has banned phones (and AirPods, smartwatches and Meta glasses) from all stops on her 45-date Lost Tour, on which she is playing material from her excellent and emotionally

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Venezuelan Gold Chased By Trump Sits Untouched

U.S. Brokered Deals in Notoriously Corrupt Industry That Makes Refiners Wary

This article is by Anatoly Kurmanaev, Tyler Pager and Rebecca R. Ruiz.

CARACAS, Venezuela — In early March, as President Trump basked in the success of a military intervention in Venezuela, he joined Interior Secretary Doug Burgum in the West Wing for a private celebration. A businessman also attended, and brought along a pile of gold.

The president looked approvingly at the 10 Venezuelan gold bars stacked in the Roosevelt Room, across from the Oval Office, White House officials recalled. Aides took photos and joked about keeping the gold.

Mr. Trump himself had once blacklisted Venezuelan gold, declaring that it destroyed the environment, poisoned people and financed gangsters and corrupt military officials. But after Mr. Trump toppled the Venezuelan president Nicolás Maduro, his view changed.

On the same day that the bars arrived at the White House, the Trump administration issued a new policy allowing traders to import Venezuelan gold from one of the world’s most violent and corrupt mining regions. The first supplies would come from a state-owned mining company that remained a designated U.S. national security threat.

“Usually, you have to be in the Olympics to bring back the gold,” Mr. Burgum later said at an energy conference, regaling listeners with the tale of how he had opened Venezuela’s gold pipeline.

The gold trading deal exemplified how Mr. Trump used the capture of Mr. Maduro to gain control of Venezuela’s resources. First, he took charge of Venezuela’s oil ex-

ports. Next, his administration turned to Venezuela’s mineral wealth.

That included one of the world’s largest untapped gold reserves at a time when the prices were near record highs and buyers were hungry for it.

The Trump administration and its business allies said that gold sales would benefit the U.S. economy, help develop Venezuela’s mining region and deprive criminals and corrupt officials of income.

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Gold to be processed. Gang territory surrounds El Callao.

Buzzing Over Myanmar Plains, Paragliders Bomb Rebel Towns

By RICHARD C. PADDOCK

A faint buzzing noise high in the sky was the first hint of danger. The source was a single-person flying machine, a motorized paraglider, that was barely visible. It cut its engine and floated quietly toward the ground.

As it reached an altitude of a few thousand feet, the pilot tossed bombs overboard that exploded with devastating effect among civilians on the ground.

Such aerial attacks — in which light, recreational aircraft, or paramotors, have been turned into deadly weapons — are carried out by the military almost daily now in central Myanmar, giving it an edge in its campaign to crush pro-democracy forces.

“In other countries, people feel happy and excited when they see a paramotor or paraglider,” said Moe Gyi, 27, a guerrilla in the Sagaing Region who has fought the junta since 2022. “But in our country, they have become weapons used to kill people. Here, when we see one, we have to run for our lives.”

Myanmar’s generals seized power from a democratically elected government in 2021 and brutally suppressed peaceful demonstrations. Many protesters fled to the countryside where they formed rebel groups, allying themselves with armed ethnic groups that have been battling the military for decades.

The ensuing civil war has killed more than 100,000 people, according to the Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project, and driven 3.7 million from their homes. The United Nations estimates that more than 12 million will face

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INTERNATIONAL A4-10	NATIONAL A11-19	ARTS C1-6	SCIENCE TIMES D1-8	OPINION A22-23
Halting Plaques for Slain Jews A German far-right party joined with two others in an eastern town to stop installing memorial plaques outside the homes of Holocaust victims. PAGE A9	Cornell Sexual Assault Inquiry Outrage over allegations in a lawsuit has prompted prosecutors to revisit the decision not to pursue charges against seven fraternity members. PAGE A17	Sharing van Gogh’s Vision Helene Kröller-Müller assembled the world’s second-largest collection of the artist’s works. Now they are on display together in a Dutch forest. PAGE C1	Surgeon’s Healing Journey A New York doctor coping with a hereditary heart ailment ended up receiving a transplant through a program he helped establish. PAGE D8	Jessica Grose PAGE A23



OCTOBER STARTS TODAY